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The microfoundations of political development: structure and agency in historical institutionalism

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Historical institutionalism has long stood for the notion that institutions represent "political legacies of concrete historical struggles." Several decades since it first emerged on the scene, however, the tradition is still deservedly criticized for its failure fully to account for the relation between structure and agency, especially as it pertains to the dynamics of the inter-group conflicts that drive processes of institutional development. This article contributes to the articulation of historical institutionalism's "social ontology" by exploring the microfoundations of political development, fleshing out "the outline of a highly distinctive view of the relationship between structure and agency" that emerged early on in the tradition's history. Without departing from historical institutionalism's foundational principles, the article proposes a potential alternative to rational choice institutionalism's *homo oeconomicus* and to sociological institutionalism's *homo sociologicus*, turning to the findings of experimental psychology and behavioral economics as the main source of insights into individual behavior.

KEYWORDS
historical institutionalism (HI), methodological individualism, microfoundation of institutional theory, political development, structure and agency

Introduction

The idea that causal explanations in the social sciences must conform to the doctrine of "methodological individualism"—in essence, "the claim that social phenomena must be explained by showing how they result from individual actions, which in turn must be explained with reference to the intentional states that motivate individual actors" (Heath, 2020)—has long served as one of the main dividing lines between the social sciences' foremost traditions of inquiry (e.g., see List and Spiekermann, 2013). Even when it is properly distinguished from fully reductionist, "atomistic" explanatory approaches (e.g., see Lukes, 1968; Wippler and Lindenberg, 1987; Bulle, 2019)—to say nothing of its frequent conflation with normative, ideological arguments for the primacy of individual over collective interests (e.g., see Weber, 1968 [1922], p. 18; Bulle and Di Iorio, 2023)—the notion that social scientific explanations must feature "microfoundations" remains contentious. The fact that methodological individualism is now so often perceived as synonymous with rational choice theory further limits its appeal. For while rational choice has always rested on empirically questionable assumptions—hence its proponents' insistence that it should be judged according to the accuracy of its predictions instead (see Friedman, 1966 [1953])—in recent decades the literature on behavioral economics has successfully challenged many of its predictions as well, all but refuting the proposition that

socialized human beings behave "as if" they reasoned like an instrumentally rational, utility-maximizing *homo oeconomicus* (e.g., see Ariely, 2008; Kahneman, 2011; Thaler, 2015; Thaler and Sunstein, 2008).

In truth, beyond postulating the "intentionality" of human beings, "methodological individualism" makes no particular claim about individual motivation, cognition, and behavior—as Elster (1983, p. 70; see also Elster, 2007, p. 53) pointed out, "intentional" explanations of individual action are defined by their focus on an agent's *desires* (or *motivations*) and *beliefs*, especially the sorts of beliefs that inform the agent's assessments of the likely consequences of his or her own actions. Of course, rational choice theory *does* make readily identifiable assumptions about individual desires and beliefs, and how they combine to produce individual action. "Methodological individualism," however, is neither coterminous with, nor reducible to, these assumptions. Indeed, while it remains the case that a fully-fledged alternative to rational choice has yet to emerge, the development of an alternative approach to "the microfoundations of politics"—one embodying methodological individualism's characteristic emphasis on the "analytical primacy of society" and the "theoretical (or explanatory) primacy of the individual (i.e., of human nature)" (see Wippler and Lindenberg, 1987, p. 138)—is long overdue.

Certainly, the assemblage of a unified theory of human behavior and its aggregation into collective, macro-level outcomes or states—even one limited to the realm of politics—is well beyond what a single journal article can accomplish. For this reason, the purpose of this article is to specify a basic set of motivational, cognitive, and behavioral tendencies that are relevant to a broad range of situations and phenomena, and to arrange them into a framework that leaves plenty of room to theorize individual action in its proper context. Partially in an attempt to narrow its scope and hence make the task at hand more manageable, the article's main focus is on theorizing the microfoundations of processes of "political development." Following Orren and Skowronek's (2004, p. 6) definition of "American Political Development," the study of political development may be described as "a study of the 'historical construction' of the present […]—one accounting for the temporal dynamics that contribute to continuity as well as change." Then again, one of the forefathers of the modern literature on political development pointed out long ago that the concept "loses its analytical content" and risks becoming "synonymous with the political history of Asia, Africa, and Latin America" as a result of overly "broad" and "all-encompassing" definitions (see Huntington, 1965, p. 390). Whereas Huntington (1965, p. 393) addressed the need for a narrower definition by equating "political development" to processes of "institutionalization," this article follows Fukuyama (2014, p. 7) in defining "political development" as "the process by which institutions emerge, evolve [or change], and eventually decay." In turn, institutions are defined as "humanly devised rules and procedures—both formal and informal" (Levitsky and Murillo, 2009, p. 117), whose main function is to "structure behavior" (Mahoney and Thelen, 2009, p. 4).

For the last several decades, the study of the development of political institutions has been the purview of the vast literature on "new institutionalism." Among the three main branches of "new institutionalism," only one—"historical institutionalism"—still lacks a distinctive set of assumptions regarding individual behavior (see Hall and Taylor, 1996, pp. 939–940). Of course, the fundamental difference between rational choice institutionalism's *homo oeconomicus* and sociological institutionalism's *homo sociologicus* is that the scholars who subscribe to the latter characteristically believe neither in the "theoretical primacy" of the individual nor in the idea that most human behavior of interest to the social sciences is purposive in nature. Indeed, *homo sociologicus* is "a thoroughly social product" (Wippler and Lindenberg, 1987, p. 143) whose actions are interpreted as the performance of "codes" or "scripts" of appropriate behavior generated by the culture in which a person is embedded.

As for historical institutionalism, it must be noted upfront that many of its practitioners themselves reject the "theoretical primacy" of the individual, opting instead to rely on structuralist explanations (see Emmenegger, 2021, p. 608). As for the rest, who acknowledge that "history is made by individuals and must be explained in terms of individual action" (Elster, 1983, p. 32), a consensus has yet to emerge regarding the manner in which historical institutionalists *should* theorize the microfoundations of processes of institutional development. Following Hall and Taylor (1996, pp. 939–940), some scholars have found considerable appeal in the notion that the eclecticism of the approach allows them to develop explanations that borrow from rational choice institutionalism's "logic of instrumentality" as well as sociological institutionalism's "logic of appropriateness." Having taken issue with the idea that historical institutionalism lacks a "distinctive social ontology," however, others have contended that the realization of the tradition's full potential rests on its development of an improved account of "the relationship between structure and agency" (see Hay and Wincott, 1998, pp. 951–953; see also Berman, 1998, p. 28; Mahoney and Snyder, 1999, p. 4; Fioretos et al., 2016, p. 15), especially as it pertains to the dynamics of inter-group conflict that drive the development of institutions (Peters et al., 2005, pp. 1277–78). Unfortunately, though some attempts have been made to specify the microfoundations of crucial aspects of political development (see Weyland, 2008; Fioretos, 2011; Capoccia, 2016; Lenz and Viola, 2017; Emmenegger, 2021), an overall framework has yet to emerge. Almost three decades since the issue was identified as one of its main shortcomings, it remains the case that historical institutionalism "is still missing the 'micro-foundations' of macro-historical change" (Bell, 2011, p. 886).

In order to provide a more explicit delineation of this article's "logical structure and procedure"—its "methodology," in Sartori's (1970, p. 1033) sense of the word—and clarify upfront what its alternative approach to the microfoundations of politics will look like, it is useful to revisit Wippler and Lindenberg's (1987, p. 141) account of the conditions that a social scientific theory must meet to qualify as *methodologically* individualist. First, the theory in question "must not require much information about each individual" to whom it is designed to apply (R1). Second, the theory "must allow us to model institutional and social structural conditions as defining intermediate goals and constraints of action," which is another way of saying that it must grant *analytical primacy* to society (R2). Third, the theory "must allow psychological (including physiological) theories to influence its assumptions," as opposed to having its assumptions "fixed by axiom" (R3). Fourth, the theory "must allow us to express our degree of ignorance explicitly" and permit the use of simplifying assumptions until the state of our knowledge improves to the point of making it possible to replace them with more complex ones (R4). Fifth, and finally, the theory "must be well corroborated" as an explanation for the "behavior of human beings in the aggregate" (R5).

The alternative framework assembled in this article reneges neither on the need for simplifying assumptions (R1) nor on the importance of formulating theories whose aggregate predictions are

corroborated empirically (R5). What is more, it satisfies R2 by building on Elster's (1983, p. 84; see also Elster, 2007 contention that explanations referring to the relationship between two "macro-states" must feature both (i) an account of how the *explanans* helps cause the individuals responsible for the *explanandum* to behave as they do (by shaping their desires and beliefs), as well as (ii) an account of how the behavior of the individuals in question combines to produce the *explanandum*. The alternative framework also departs from Friedman (1966 [1953]) by emphasizing the importance of knowing that a theory's aggregate predictions are corroborated for the very reasons postulated by the theory. Indeed, the framework does not simply *allow* "psychological theories" to "influence its assumptions;" more foundationally, this article looks to the findings of experimental psychology and behavioral economics as the main source of insights informing the development of theories whose assumptions are consistent with the current state of our knowledge regarding the manner in which socialized human beings think and act (R4) (see also Tooby and Cosmides, 1992; Hatemi and McDermott, 2011).

The attempt made in this article to provide an alternative framework accounting for the microfoundations of political development in a historical institutionalist perspective begins in the next section with a discussion of historical institutionalism's "social ontology," focusing on the fundamental importance of inter-group conflict as the "engine" of political development. The ensuing three sections are dedicated to the formulation of a model of individual behavior accounting for the role of agency in the mobilization of organized groups whose conflicts drive the development of institutions. Subsequently, an effort is also made to address the relationship between structure and agency, concentrating on the manner in which the behavior of the actors responsible for macro-historical change is affected by the structural features of their environment. The article concludes with a reflection on how the adoption of the "microfoundations" specified in these pages can improve upon historical institutionalist explanations of political development, especially when compared to theories relying on rational choice institutionalism's *homo oeconomicus* and sociological institutionalism's *homo sociologicus*.

The engine of political development

A core element of historical institutionalism's "social ontology" is the idea that inter-group conflict—"conflict among rival groups for scarce resources" (Hall and Taylor, 1996, p. 937)—is the engine of political development. Institutions, that is, are typically regarded as "the political legacies of concrete historical struggles" (Mahoney and Thelen, 2009, p. 7), in that their contents reflect the outcomes of successive rounds of conflict. Indeed, institutions almost invariably feature as crucial *intermediate* goals for rival groups competing to enact rules and procedures that favor the perpetuation, or the expansion, of certain asymmetries of power, or the entrenchment of particular standards of legitimacy (see Mahoney, 2000, pp. 521–525). The identification of inter-group conflict as the "engine" of political development has a number of crucial implications. For one thing, the variation observed—between countries as well as over time within countries—in the contents of institutions, their stability, and the extent to with which they shape the behavior of relevant political actors must hinge on the sorts of groups that have emerged as the main contenders, their respective size and strength, their world views and visions for the future, the alliances formed between them, and the outcomes of their strategic interactions. It also follows from these considerations that the specification of the "microfoundations" of political development must concentrate on formulating an explanation—one rooted in the intentional behavior of individuals—for the effectiveness with which rival groups mobilize prospective supporters.

Until a few decades ago, of course, social scientists treated the question of how organized groups emerge on the scene as relatively straightforward and unproblematic, assuming that political organizations should form whenever a large enough number of people in a society come to realize that they share a common interest or grievance. In that perspective, a country's organizational landscape should largely *reflect* its social cleavage structure. Olson's (1965) book *The Logic of Collective Action* successfully challenged this view, showing that organizations working to provide non-excludable "public goods" on behalf of a sizable constituency must overcome the "collective action problem"—that is to say, mobilize large numbers of adherents in spite of the tendency of instrumentally rational individuals to "free ride" on the efforts of others to avoid incurring the private costs associated with active participation. Alas, though Olson's (1965) statement of the "collective action problem" constitutes one of rational choice's signal contributions, the attempts that have been made since then to formulate rational choice *solutions* to the problem have not proven nearly as compelling.

Rational choice solutions to the collective action problem center on the capacity of political entrepreneurs to administer selective (dis) incentives to individuals targeted for mobilization. Certainly, while the idea that participation in collective action is motivated by material self-interest has its proponents (e.g., see Tullock, 1971), rationalists are frequently willing to concede that it is beyond the capacity of any organization to coerce or bribe many thousands of people into participating in its activities, especially when considerable costs or risks are involved. That being the case, however, stretching the definition of "selective incentives" to include an "individual's sense of duty to class, country, democratic institutions, race, humanity, the rulers, God, or a revolutionary brotherhood as well as his taste for conspiracy, violence, and adventure" (Silver, 1974, pp. 64–65; see also Muller and Opp, 1986, p. 473) not only deprives the approach of its predictive power (see Simon, 1995, p. 49), but ultimately does more to undermine than it does to uphold rational choice theory. For while it is no doubt the case that the maximization of expected utility does not require an actor to behave selfishly—let alone pursue material self-interest to the exclusion of everything else—it defies credulity that actions inspired by "a sense of duty" or "a taste for conspiracy, violence, and adventure" would involve anything resembling an optimizing or maximizing calculus. As Elster (2000, p. 692) has pointed out, that someone is "reward-sensitive" does not mean that he or she is "reward-maximizing."

The starting point for the account of individual agency provided in the remainder of this article is the recognition that while all collective behavior is the aggregate result of individual actions and decisions, individuals typically do not act in accordance with the requirements of "instrumental rationality." As the bourgeoining literature on "bounded rationality" has shown, this is the case even in situations where individuals are pursuing self-interested, "utilitarian goals" (see Weyland, 2006). Still, as Elster (2007); (see also Simon, 1995, p. 45) has suggested, intentional, goal-oriented behavior can be explained by uncovering the agents' underlying motivations and the beliefs that induced the agents to opt for a particular course of action

in order to satisfy their desires. The following two sections address these issues in turn. With regard to *desires* or *motivations*, having established that the solution to the "collective action problem" must account for the tendency of socialized human beings to pursue goals that transcend material self-interest, it becomes imperative to address the genesis of alternative motivations and their power to drive individual behavior, as opposed to taking individual preferences as "given" or as "revealed" by the actions they purport to explain. With regard to *beliefs*, the analysis places special emphasis on the manner in which individuals are known to form expectations regarding the behavior of others and the likely consequences of their own actions, as well as on the decisive role that the emotions play in their decision-making process.

An alternative approach to individual motivation

What, then, are the sets of motivations characteristically involved in the solution of the collective action problem? Francis Fukuyama's landmark study of *The Origins of Political Order* (2011) features a brief re-statement of the importance of a universal phenomenon to which the same author had previously ascribed a crucial role in the progression of human history: the "struggle for recognition" (see Fukuyama, 1992, pp. 143–208). "Recognition"—defined as "an intersubjective state of mind by which one human being acknowledges the worth or status of another human being, or of that human being's gods, customs, and beliefs"—was described in Fukuyama's (1992, pp. 144–145) original treatment as the centerpiece of a "non-materialist historical dialectic that is much richer in its understanding of human motivation than the Marxist version," one accounting for "the prideful and assertive side of human nature that is responsible for driving most wars and political conflicts."

Fukuyama (2011, p. 41) reiterated more recently that "a great deal of contemporary politics revolves around demands for recognition particularly on the part of groups that have historical reasons for believing their worth has not been adequately acknowledged." Such demands may well have an "economic component." Research on human motivation, however, generally supports the contention that "economic resources" are often "markers of dignity rather than ends in themselves" (for variants of this argument, see Kahneman, 2011, p. 342; Baumeister, 2005, p. 151; Veblen, 2007 [1899], pp. 22–39). Something quite similar may be said with reference to demands of a more ideological nature, as well as individual behavior designed to uphold particular standards of appropriateness. For while Fukuyama (2011, p. 442) does contend that theories of political development must treat "ideas" as "fundamental causes," the internalization of the "social visions" (see Sowell, 2007 [1987]) and "moral narratives" (see Lakoff, 2009) on which political ideologies are based—or for that matter the absorption of "subjective orientations and beliefs about what is appropriate or morally correct" (see Mahoney, 2000, p. 523)—is frequently the *consequence*, not the cause, of "people bind[ing] themselves into political teams" (see Haidt, 2012, p. xxxiii) or otherwise acquiring a social identity.

The "struggle for recognition," then, provides a more fundamental explanation for rational choice institutionalism's "logic of instrumentality" as well as for sociological institutionalism's "logic of appropriateness." It does so by identifying in the desire for status and public reputation the fundamental driver of actions taken in the pursuit of material advantage as well as actions taken, sometimes at the expense of material self-interest, as a means by which to "fit in" or "do the right thing" as one's social group defines it. In both cases, the reward for acting in a certain way is an emotional one (see Sapolsky, 2017, Ch. 2). Correspondingly, Fukuyama (2011, p. 39) ascribes the pursuit of "inter-subjective recognition" to emotional responses that are "genetically based" (see also Baumeister, 2005, pp. 135–159; Haidt, 2012, pp. 237–240; Sapolsky, 2017, pp. 456–462). Broadening Fukuyama's discussion of the phenomenon's "biological roots," it may be ventured that modern-day inter-group struggles for recognition are driven by universal psychological dispositions human beings have acquired over the course of the species' evolutionary history. Foremost among them is the human propensity for "status-seeking behavior," rooted in basic desires for subjective well-being, for the control of our social environment, for self-esteem, and for the approval of others—all of which have a firmly established evolutionary basis (see Baumeister, 2005, Ch. 3). As Wright (1995, pp. 259–260) pointed out, "the range of things that can bring status in different cultures" varies widely, but "the mental machinery driving these various activities is fundamentally the same."

Incidentally, while political scientists have only recently rediscovered social status as "one of the most important motivators of human behavior" (see Wohlforth and Kang, 2009)—the rediscovery was momentous enough to draw the attention of the *New York Times* (see Edsall, 2020)—the experimental findings attesting to its significance have borne out conjectures developed over centuries of political philosophy. As Fukuyama (1992: 147) pointed out, it was Hegel who originally credited "the desire for recognition" for perpetually ensnaring human beings "in a violent fight to the death for pure prestige." By that time, Thomas Hobbes (1994 [1668]) had already characterized the quest for public worth ("dignity") and the pursuit of any outward sign of power ("honour") (Part I: Ch. X. pars. 18–47) as "a general inclination of all" (Part I: Ch. XI, par. 2) and as a virtual guarantee that human beings will be constantly engaged in internecine fights for "glory," in which the slightest "sign of undervalue" shown against one's person or relations can lead to violence (Part I: Ch. XIII, pars. 6–7). Likewise, David Hume (1960 [1739/40], p. 332) wrote at some length of our "vanity or the desire of reputation," while his contemporary, Adam Smith, identified "the desire of becoming the proper object of the respect of our equals" as "perhaps the strongest of our desires," conjecturing that human beings are not just after the approbation of their peers, but also the feeling that they are actually deserving of it (see Smith, 2002 [1759], p. 249).

Rather more recently, Carnegie (1981 [1936], p. 17–19) cited the works of Sigmund Freud, Thomas Dewey, and William James in support of the contention that the "desire for a feeling of importance" ranks among humanity's strongest and deepest impulses, adding that no civilization would have been possible if our ancestors had not pursued "this flaming urge". Consistent with that reasoning, Adler (1956 [1934], p. 448) identified in the universal "striving for superiority" the key to our willingness to participate in group behavior—social movements are said to require "thousands of human sacrifices" made in exchange for a promise, however illusory, of an "enhanced sense of importance". Even when personal sacrifices are required, people can be motivated to act in ways that further the interests of a group to the extent that they feel that the "sense of personal importance" they derive from their self-image and public reputation is at stake.

Of course, Fukuyama (2011, p. 41) himself recognized that demands for the recognition of certain groups, or for the recognition of "an abstraction, like a god, a flag, or a holy place," require more than the individual desire for status. The first requirement is the human capacity for abstraction and symbolic thinking. The second requirement is the "groupishness" (see Haidt, 2012) human beings developed as a result of an evolutionary process that has equipped us with the capacity to "transcend self-interest and lose ourselves (temporarily and ecstatically) in something larger than ourselves" (223). Perhaps most importantly, a mountain of experimental evidence attests to the fact that human beings routinely engage in "social categorization" (see Tajfel and Turner, 1986) in order to define their place in society, or for that matter that people have a tendency to rely on their social identities for self-evaluation as well as to develop strong emotional attachments to their social groups, adopt markers that signal group affiliations, and practice "parochial altruism"—that is, act in ways that further the interests of strangers perceived to be fellow group members and discriminate against equally unknown, nameless members of other groups, sometimes at great personal cost. "Parochial altruism"—which includes, at least in some, a disposition for "suicidal self-sacrifice" (see Pagel, 2012, p. 73) in the service of group interests, as well as a propensity to harm those who threaten the group—is one of the most prominent features of the "cooperative psychology" that has emerged over the course of our evolutionary history, enabling us to live in cooperative groups that are sufficiently cohesive to survive and thrive in the face of challenges presented by our physical environment (see Choi and Bowles, 2007; Efferson et al., 2008).

In cohesive groups with established moral codes and effective mechanisms to enforce compliance, negative emotions like guilt or shame can be powerful motivators inducing individuals to sacrifice their material self-interest for the group, as are the social rewards accruing to those who demonstrate the strongest commitment to it (see Pagel, 2012, p. 222). At the same time, the tendency of individuals to behave in this fashion even when they have no expectation of social rewards or sanctions suggests that acting in the service of a cause larger than oneself can be the source of enough pleasure, self-satisfaction, and pride to override the costs and risks involved. The pro-group activities that help members feel good about themselves extend to acts of aggression against out-groups as well as acts of "altruistic punishment" (see Boyd et al., 2003) and "moralistic aggression" (see Trivers, 1971) against the "enemy within"—that is to say, in-groups who come to be perceived as a threat to the group's prosperity and cohesion on account of their presumed treachery, deviancy, or freeloading.

The formation and processing of individual beliefs

Much like the desires or motivations involved, the *beliefs* that inform individual decisions to participate in collective action are seldom formed and processed in accordance with the assumptions of rational choice theory—that is to say, based on objective, dispassionate assessments of reality. Indeed, human beings have repeatedly been shown to be susceptible to a host of cognitive biases (for a useful list, see Shermer, 2012, pp. 301–326)—some of which derive from our extensive reliance on inferential shortcuts and cognitive heuristics (see Weyland, 2006, pp. 6–8)—that distort the manner in which information is processed and decisions are made (e.g., see Kahneman, 2011; Thaler, 2015; Sapolsky, 2017), beginning with the "pre-conscious processing of visual stimuli" that "guides what the visual system presents to conscious awareness" (see Trivers, 2011, p. 142). Perhaps most prominently, the vast literature on "motivated reasoning" (see Kunda, 1990; see also Elster, 2007, pp. 133–143) demonstrated long ago that our motivations exert outsized influence on the way beliefs are formed and accessed in our decision-making process.

The psychology of "social categorization" and "parochial altruism" should also be expected to have as strong an impact on our beliefs as it has on our motivations. As Haidt (2012, p. xxxiii) has argued, the moral beliefs people acquire through their identification with a social group are crucial to the group's cohesion. Morality, however, both "binds and blinds," for when "people bind themselves into political teams that share moral narratives," they tend to "become blind to alternative moral worlds." Indeed, if Beetham (1991, p. 27) is right to say that human beings are "moral agents," Sapolsky (2017, p. 481) reminds us that "moral decision making" is "implicit, intuitive, and anchored in emotion." Aside from their role in defining appropriate or desirable behavior, the moral beliefs we acquire through our social identities often drive our perception of reality, blind us to disconfirming evidence, and cause us to make snap judgments we subsequently feel compelled to "defend, justify, and rationalize" (see Shermer, 2012, p. 6), frequently at the cost of deceiving ourselves, in order to satisfy our "obsession for righteousness" (see Haidt, 2012, p. xix) and uphold a sense of our "beneffactance" (see Greenwald, 1980)—i.e., the notion that "I am nice and in control" (see Pinker, 1999, p. 423).

Moral beliefs become the basis for rendering moral judgments intuitively, without deliberation, to the extent that they are capable of generating automatic emotional responses to certain events, acts, words, and other stimuli (see Haidt, 2012). As for how or why strong emotions become attached to certain beliefs, the literature specifies a variety of conceivable pathways. Political entrepreneurs can induce a sense of "cognitive ease" through the sheer repetition of a particular message—repetition gives an illusion of familiarity that improves mood and makes people more comfortable, confident, and trusting, if less vigilant and more superficial (see Kahneman, 2011, pp. 59–70)—while the manipulation of context, wording, and imagery can serve to activate certain emotional responses to a particular message or argument, thereby promoting or strengthening the association. Perhaps even more powerful are those values and beliefs that are bound up with someone's sense of self (see Taylor, 2006, Ch. 2). That includes the values and beliefs espoused by the groups with which a person identifies, depending on the extent to which the groups in question define the individual's identity. Accordingly, anything that makes a particular social group more central to its members' sense of who they are—external threats and competition with other groups often being powerful boosters of group attachment and loyalty—also increases the emotional power of the group's core beliefs.

Once again, an implication of this reasoning is that the process by which beliefs are acquired, reinforced, and potentially changed frequently has very little to do with the pursuit of "the truth." As Baumeister (2005, p. 178) has noted, people generally have "strong preferences" about "the truth"—Haidt (2012, p. 95) explains that "self-interest, social identities, and strong emotions make people want or even *need* to reach pre-ordained conclusions" in order to protect or boost self-esteem—and share a universal predisposition to distort information in order to fit existing beliefs and impose order on a chaotic reality. The combination of what Shermer (2012, p. 6) calls "patternicity" (i.e., "the tendency to find meaningful patterns in both

meaningful and meaningless data") and "agenticity" (i.e., "the tendency to infuse patterns with meaning, intention, and agency") leads to the kinds of "illusions of causality" (see Kahneman, 2011, p. 76) upon which superstition and magical thinking are based.

Beliefs acquired in this fashion also tend to be reinforced as a result of our susceptibility to the influence of authority figures (see Milgram, 1963) and fellow group members (see Bond, 2015; Sunstein, 2011). The mere suggestion that "most other people" in their communities are doing something thought to benefit society has proven effective in motivating subjects to buy products (see Cialdini, 2009), pay back taxes (see Thaler and Sunstein, 2008), or even turn out to vote (see Issenberg, 2012). As a series of experiments conducted in the 1950s have demonstrated, moreover, subjects are sometimes willing to "deny the evidence of their senses" in order to conform to grossly erroneous judgments rendered by an otherwise unanimous group, having generally taken their own departure from the consensus view as "reflective of some personal deficiency" (see Asch, 2012, p. 20). In turn, the desire to fit in and the drive to rationalize one's own behavior have been shown in experiments dating back to Sherif (1937) to cause the internalization of judgments or ideas subjects came to express as a result of peer pressure or induced compliance. As Wright (1995, p. 264) has observed, our drive for status and our desire to impress others "may together be responsible for most of the dishonesty in our species."

The manner in which people access their beliefs as they ponder how to accomplish their objectives also tends to bear little resemblance to the assumptions of rational choice theory. Most importantly, rational choice overlooks the role that the emotions play in a person's decision-making process. Even in the common event that our emotional impulses are *not* strong enough to get us to act altogether without regard for the consequences, the emotions remain crucial to the choices we make to behave in particular ways. Many emotions have "action tendencies"—which Elster (2007, p. 147) characterizes as "more than dispositions"—that serve as "urges to perform specific actions." Among other things, moreover, a person's identification with a group or movement can be the source of reflexes, affects, and moods that increase the likelihood that the person will behave in the service of group interests or goals in pursuit of an expected emotional reward (see Goodwin et al., 2004). More subtle, but no less crucial, is the manner in which the emotions allow us to access information that is not available to conscious processing but is required to engage in efficient decision-making—that is to say, to override those conscious calculations of costs and benefits that are too time-consuming and cognitively effortful for most of the choices we make on an everyday basis (see McDermott, 2004, p. 694). In particular, Damasio's (2012) "somatic marker hypothesis" posits that the emotions provide us with an instinctive sense of what causes pleasure and pain, based on experience. Once certain bodily sensations become tied to particular sorts of events or situations, finding ourselves in similar contexts alerts us that a reward or punishment is likely to follow if we act in a certain way.

Once again, Sapolsky (2017, Ch. 3, Ch. 11–12) presented a wealth of evidence in support of the notion that our brains are especially sensitive and reactive to external stimuli pertaining to social status and group membership. Given the difference in the ways in which human beings respond to threats and opportunities (see Kahneman and Tversky, 1979), it stands to reason that the cues alerting us to the threat of "social uncertainty"—perhaps above all, the instability of (our position on) prevailing social hierarchies and the vulnerability of our social groups to external and internal challenges—would feature among the most powerful. Typical sources of these stimuli are the "word framing" and "verbal priming" activities in which partisan groups routinely engage (see Sapolsky, 2017, Ch. 3). Moreover, insofar as the stimuli in question serve primarily to activate pre-existing behavioral tendencies, these cues should increase the propensity of those who identify most strongly with the group to perform behaviors they have come instinctively to associate with the preservation of the group's cohesion and with the protection of their status—social cooperation, conformism, parochial altruism, moral aggression, and altruistic punishment conceivably foremost among them.

Individual behavior, collective action, and inter-group conflict

A core assumption made in the foregoing discussion is that the motivations as well as the beliefs involved in collective action and inter-group conflict are to some extent "endogenous" to the process of mobilization, as both are sensitive to what political entrepreneurs say and do in an effort to increase the size of their support and the likelihood that their supporters will sacrifice their time and material self-interest to engage in collective behavior. In other words, the individuals targeted for mobilization in a group or movement have pre-existing desires and beliefs. However, the activities in which the group's leaders and rank-and-file members engage in to mobilize support—including but not limited to the use of rhetoric and the deployment of moral/historical narratives, symbols, and rituals—can partially re-shape a person's desires and beliefs in ways that alter the individual's propensity for active participation. Once again, the success of these efforts hinges on the effectiveness with which the group has made individual followers to feel bound to the movement and (perhaps especially) to each other, as well as on the group's centrality to its followers' sense of self.

Recall that the central tenet of the approach formulated in these pages is that the engine of political development is the conflict between organized groups. Of course, every society is different with regard to the main groups that dominate the political scene, the issues that divide them, and their patterns of support in the population, all of which depends on *who* was most successful in solving the collective action problem and *how* the actors in question went about solving it. An important implication of this reasoning is that two countries with a very similar demographic or socio-economic structure may well end up with dissimilar political landscapes. In each of these contexts, individual decisions are not *determined* by a person's demographic background and socio-economic status. Rather, to the extent that demographic and/or socio-economic traits correlate with the adoption of particular attitudes and partisan identities in a given society, they do so as a result of what Przeworski and Sprague (1986, pp. 7–8) once described as "a process of creating images in society, of forging collective identities, of mobilizing commitments to particular projects for the future" among citizens who share a particular set of traits, led by agents vying with one another to "impose a particular form of organization upon the life of a society."

What does "a process of creating images in society" have to do with the mobilization of political support? Academic work on partisanship in the United States (see Green et al., 2002, p. 8) illustrates one possibility, having found that voters identify with partisan groups by

"call[ing] to mind some mental image, or stereotype, of what these sorts of people are like and squar[ing] these images with their own self-conception." Identification with a partisan group, then, becomes a question of how individuals "think of themselves in relation to" group stereotypes: "the terms Democrats and Republicans clearly call to mind different constituent groups, and how people feel about these social categories has a great deal to do with whether they identify with a partisan group and, if so, which one."

All in all, while it is longstanding practice to assume that a nation's political landscape will to various extents reflect the structure of the country's social cleavages, the reasoning articulated in this section provides an explanation for why the resemblance may not be all that strong at times. Social cleavages, that is, may be understood as a factor that constrains the range of possible outcomes, by determining what social constituencies are available for mobilization in a given society. However, whether a particular constituency is mobilized, the grievances and goals that successfully motivate its members, the ideas and narratives that prove effective in their mobilization, and the rivalries and alliances that end up forming as a result have a strong element of contingency, as do all "situations, in which people's behavior or people's choices depend on the choices of other people" (see Schelling, 1978, p. 14). In each case, what outcomes ultimately take shape hinge on the specific manner in which rival political entrepreneurs respond to the challenges, incentives, and opportunities presented by the structure of social cleavages and by the prevailing configuration of institutions.

As Fukuyama (1992, p. 182) has pointed out, demands for "intersubjective recognition" come in two major varieties. Such demands may reflect a determination, on the part of a person or a group, to see others acknowledge their status as equal to someone else's or as superior to someone else's. The "struggle for recognition," therefore, is fundamentally about the inequalities sanctioned by prevailing social hierarchies. Of course, while the workings of hierarchical societies and the attendant inequalities create the *potential* for struggles over recognition to break out, proponents of social identity theory have long understood that status inequalities do not always lead to conflict. Crucial to the avoidance of conflict is the presence of a "consensually accepted status system" (see Tajfel and Turner, 1986, p. 12). Indeed, just as human beings can pursue status as if driven by a "higher, spiritual need" (see Pinker, 1999, p. 493), natural selection also equipped us with psychological mechanisms that allow us to reconcile ourselves to status hierarchies, thereby sparing us the costs of fighting losing battles (see Wright, 1995). As Jost et al. (2004, p. 885) have noted, even "highly hierarchical systems" are often maintained through "the complicity of members of subordinate groups." Among other things, the literature on "system justification theory" demonstrates that people tend to rationalize systems over which they have no control by embracing legitimizing myths and ideologies, including the very stereotypes that serve to justify their enduring inferiority (Jost et al., 2004, p. 909).

Tajfel and Turner (1986, p. 12) also argued that the members of subordinate groups can challenge existing status hierarchies only to the extent that they are capable of imagining "cognitive alternatives" to the status quo. It follows from this consideration that the members of subordinate groups are most likely to develop a "positive ethnocentric identity" and choose strategies of "social competition" in pursuit of equal or dominant status when the situation becomes unstable and illegitimate, sometimes as a consequence of an actual *decrease* in their "objective deprivation." Aside from the fact that inter-group comparisons become more plausible when inter-group differences are reduced—as Hume (1960 [1739/40], p. 378) famously observed, "great disproportion" either "keeps us from comparing ourselves with what is remote from us" or "diminishes the effects of the comparison"—the phenomenon sometimes referred to as the "revolution of rising expectations" is consistent with what has been described as a "general rule" of "motivation theory," according to which "getting begets wanting" (see Baumeister, 2005, p. 161).

It should also be noted, consistent with the work on "prospect theory" (see Kahneman and Tversky, 1979), that insofar as individuals value (and fear) losses far more than they value (and covet) equivalent gains, the preference to maintain the status quo held by members of challenged dominant groups should be more intense than the preference for change held by the members of subordinate groups who have come to reject their "consensual inferiority." Indeed, social identity theory predicts that groups whose superiority is challenged, at least to the extent that they still perceive it as legitimate, will often "react in an intensely discriminatory fashion" (see Tajfel and Turner, 1986, p. 22) and redouble their efforts to defend the status quo (see also Baumeister, 1996). As Weyland (2019, 2021) has found, disproportionate loss aversion on the part of conservative elites and the general public played a major role in the diffusion of authoritarianism in interwar Europe and in Latin America at the height of the Cold War. Combined with their widespread reliance on cognitive heuristics, which exaggerated the severity of the threat, loss aversion induced conservatives to resort to levels of violence far greater than what was needed strictly to defend the status quo.

Structure and agency in historical institutionalism

The approach to individual behavior presented in these pages comports no derogation of historical institutionalism's foundational principles, its emphasis on the "big questions" of political development, its commitment to the study of macro-historical processes, and its focus on the importance of time. Indeed, the framework is highly consistent with "the outline of a distinctive view of the relationship between structure and agency" (see Hay and Wincott, 1998, pp. 953–954) that emerged early on in the tradition's development—in a nutshell, the notion that "actors are strategic, seeking to realize complex, contingent, and often changing goals" in a context "viewed largely in institutional terms" that "favors certain strategies over others" and on the basis of "perceptions" that are "at best incomplete" and "often inaccurate." Likewise, the account of the role of institutions provided in this section does not depart from historical institutionalism's distinctive view of institutions as "the subject and focus of political struggle" and "the contingent nature of such struggles" (954–955).

While the idea that institutions are "political legacies of concrete historical struggles" (see Mahoney and Thelen, 2009, p. 7) is well-established in the historical institutionalist literature, this article's focus on inter-group struggles over recognition as the engine of political development helps to complete the articulation of the approach's social ontology. A crucial implication of the account provided so far is that organized groups fight over institutions for two sets of reasons. First, they fight to establish their preferred institutional arrangements because of what those arrangements mean, in and of themselves, about the status and dignity of particular constituencies. Indeed, the

way a group fulfills its demands for recognition is typically by establishing a set of rules that formalize and give some permanence to the group's status and enshrine into law its treatment as equal or as superior to other groups in society. Second, organized groups fight to establish their preferred institutional arrangements because institutions constitute a means by which to achieve particular ends.

As historical institutionalists have long understood, institutions have "distributive" or "power-distributional" consequences. Institutions, that is, "structure power relations" between political actors—"privileging some and putting others at a disadvantage" (Thelen and Steinmo, 1992, p. 2)—and influence "the character and outcome of group conflict" in a way that helps determine winners and losers (see Hall and Taylor, 1996, p. 938). As a result, different institutional arrangements may be expected to have very different consequences for the distribution of power and material resources in society, which are in turn crucial determinants of the policies a country pursues and the trajectory of political development it ends up undertaking. More specifically, organized groups may be expected to fight over institutions in order to initiate, strengthen, disrupt, or reverse the self-reinforcing or "positive feedback" mechanisms responsible for the entrenchment and expansion of asymmetries of power (see Mahoney, 2000, p. 521; see also Pierson, 2004, pp. 36–37). Institutions also represent a means to an end because of their "normative force." That is, to the extent that people are motivated by the desire to "do the right thing" and behave in ways that help them "fit in" with the groups that define their social identities, institutions provide behavioral models that help them distinguish between appropriate and inappropriate conduct. What is more, the tendency of people to adjust their attitudes, preferences, and beliefs retroactively to align with their behavior may induce those who act in accordance with the behavioral expectations of an existing institution to rationalize their conduct by convincing themselves of the legitimacy of the institution that elicited their conformist behavior, of the validity of the ideas the institution embodies, and, perhaps, of the justice of the configuration of institutions constitutive of the regime currently in place.

For an illustration of this logic, consider the central role that the politics of recognition and resentment plays in the global struggle for democracy. Democracy appeals to subordinate, marginal, or excluded populations because a regime embodying principles of popular sovereignty, individual freedom, and equality satisfies their desire to live in a society that recognizes their full citizenship and their status and dignity as human beings. Moreover, groups denied participation in nondemocratic regimes conceivably see democratic rights as a way to improve their livelihoods. Civil rights protect citizens from arbitrary government actions, thereby allowing them to pursue their life goals on an equal footing with everyone else. And, through their political rights, the majority of the electorate can enact policies that provide freedom from exploitation, expand access to government services, and guarantee them a better standard of living. Conversely, those opposed to the establishment of democratic regimes—a country's elites and, especially in underdeveloped societies, frequently the middle class—do not only fear the implications that majority rule may have for their wealth, power, and status; rather, what superordinate groups often find hardest to swallow is that democratic governments are chosen by segments of the population they regard as morally and intellectually inferior, and hence unworthy of running the country through their elected representatives. In turn, the levels of resentment occasioned by the empowerment of subordinate groups should conceivably be highest in societies where shared "higher-level" (i.e., national) identities are weakest and where differences in status and power overlap with divisions of race, ethnicity, language, and/or religion (see Simon and Oakes, 2006).

A similar reasoning to the one made in this section with regard to the role of institutions also applies to the manner in which historical institutionalists *should* treat the role of structure more generally. Methodological individualism does not require us to assume that structural conditions like the international context, levels of development, patterns of inequality, class relations, available technologies, and the demographic make-up of society do not matter. On the contrary, they do matter because they affect the prevalence of certain identities, motivations, and beliefs in a given society. Moreover, structural conditions contribute to defining the context in which inter-group conflict takes place, in that they present political actors with constraints they must contend with and limit the range of options available to them in pursuit of their objectives. In so doing, structural conditions render different outcomes and trajectories of development more or less likely at the outset. By the same token, the relaxation of structural constraints has long been credited with giving rise to "critical junctures" (see Capoccia and Kelemen, 2007) that provide actors with greater freedom of choice and increase a society's openness to a wider range of developmental paths. Structure, however, does not *determine* outcomes (see Bulle, 2019, p. 162). What does determine how political development unfolds is what political actors ultimately choose to do given the constraints they face, as well as the results of their strategic interactions, whose indeterminacy and unpredictability *ex ante* accounts for the ubiquity of path inefficiencies and unintended consequences (see Hay and Wincott, 1998, pp. 954–955; see also Pierson, 2004).

Human, all too human

The inquiry conducted in this article into the microfoundations of processes of political development is built around three fundamental premises. Following Hayek (1942, pp. 276–277), the first premise is that while political phenomena are most commonly "the unintended or undesigned consequences of the actions of many men" (and women), we can hardly claim to understand any phenomenon we have not explained with reference to the behavior of the individuals responsible for bringing it about. The second premise is that social and political phenomena across time and space rest on common sets of microfoundations—indeed, following Machiavelli (2003 [1531], p. 52), that the same desires (*desiderii*) and dispositions (*omori*) account for the fact that "the same occurrences are often observed in different peoples." The third fundamental premise is that rational choice theory, with which methodological individualism is often treated as effectively synonymous, has been so thoroughly debunked that its survival, beyond its usefulness in introducing undergraduates to economics (see Kahneman, 2011, p. 286), is down to Shepsle's (1995, p. 217) "First Law of Wing Walking:" "Don't let go of something until you have something else to hold on to."

The present study, while also committed to "the analytical primacy of society" and "the theoretical primacy of the individual," replaces rational choice's conception of individual behavior as driven by a dispassionate, instrumental calculus with a framework that stresses the "distinctly bounded" (see Weyland, 2008, p. 286) nature of human rationality, emphasizing the moral and emotional basis of intentional individual

action. Above all, the specification of the microfoundations of political development contributes to the articulation of historical institutionalism's social ontology by endowing it with a highly distinctive account of the role of individual agency—and of its interplay with structure—in the inter-group conflicts that drive the development of institutions, which has long been identified as one of historical institutionalism's main blindspots and "frontiers" (see Fioretos et al., 2016, p. 15). The account improves upon previous attempts by historical institutionalists to investigate the microfoundations of political development primarily by virtue of its generality and portability. For whereas most previous efforts have concentrated on particular cases, epochs, domains, and/or aspects of the development of institutions, this article provides an overall framework applicable to a broad range of situations and phenomena across time and space, combining insights derived from "human universals" (see Brown, 1991) and well-established experimental findings in the fields of cognitive psychology and behavioral economics.

Ultimately, the success or failure of the framework assembled in this study will hinge on its capacity to support theories that improve upon historical institutionalist explanations for processes of institutional development. Above all, its neglect of the role of individual agency and its over-reliance on structuralist explanations have long been blamed for historical institutionalism's tendency to overemphasize stability and inertia, which in turn "makes it difficult to account for profound political change" (see Weyland, 2008, p. 281). The theory of agency specified in this article makes reference to a host of behavioral tendencies whose aggregation may favor stability as well as change. Among them, focusing on the individual drive for status and on the circumstances most likely to trigger inter-group struggles over recognition holds perhaps the greatest promise of yielding improved explanations of institutional change. As Trivers (2011, p. 65) has observed, "revolutionary moments often seem to occur in history when large numbers of individuals have a change in consciousness regarding themselves and their status."

In practical terms, the framework developed in these pages frees historical institutionalists from having to choose between rational choice institutionalism's "calculus approach" and sociological institutionalism's "cultural approach" (see Hall and Taylor, 1996)—or, alternatively, from having to concoct their own admixtures of the two each time they set out to study the political development of one nation or another. Indeed, not only does the framework account for behavior motivated by self-interest as well as by considerations of appropriateness; what is more, it provides a more fundamental explanation for both, rooted in assumptions regarding human nature that are more realistic and more consistent with the empirical record than those undergirding the constructs of *homo oeconomicus* and *homo sociologicus*, thereby a balance between "undersocialized and oversocialized views of action" (see Emmenegger, 2021, p. 614). As behavioral economists are fond of reminding us (see Thaler and Sunstein, 2008, pp. 6–8; see also Kahneman, 2011), we already have a name for purposeful agents who do what they can—given a host of cognitive biases that systematically distort the way information is processed and decisions are made—to accomplish their life goals, maintain a positive self-image, and earn the respect of those around them, sometimes in the face of great complexity and information overload. The name, of course, is "Humans."

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